



Men of the US Coast Guard cutter *Spencer* watch the explosion of a depth charge that sank a German U-boat in the Atlantic on April 17.



Women at war

A US poster suggests that working in munitions factories can be as glamorous as joining the various uniformed women's services.

Germany came under **heavy air attack** through 1943. RAF Bomber Command, equipped with the new Lancaster bomber, achieved a spectacular success in the “**Dambusters**” raid in May. Using “bouncing bombs,” Lancasters made a low-level night attack on four Ruhr dams, breaching two of them. In July, bombers saturated the port city of **Hamburg** with incendiary devices. In hot, dry weather conditions, separate fires blended into a single immense firestorm. More than 37,000 people were killed, most of them civilians.

While the RAF bombed Germany by night, the **US Army Air Force** began a **daylight bombing campaign**. The US bombers, bristling with guns, were expected to fight off attacks by German aircraft and drop bombs on targets using technologically advanced bombsights. In practice, the B-17s and B-24s suffered alarmingly heavy losses and precision bombing proved hard to achieve under combat conditions.

The **impact of bombing** on the German civilian population was huge. Aside from the casualties, hundreds of thousands were made homeless and there were severe food shortages. Over **two million children** were **evacuated** from the cities. Many factories were relocated underground to avoid the bombing.



Flying fortress

The crew of an American Eighth Air Force B-17 Flying Fortress at a base in England prepares for a bombing mission over Germany. The Eighth Air Force lost 26,000 men between 1942 and 1945.

prevented food from reaching the starving.

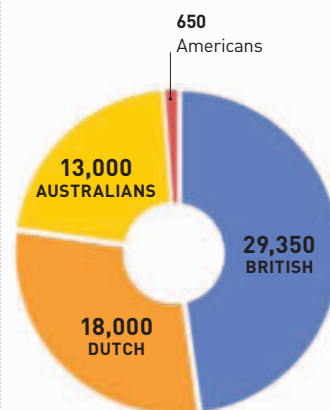
In Asia, 60,000 Allied prisoners of war (POWs) and

The shortages experienced by German civilians were replicated, in greater or lesser degree, in all European countries, including neutral Spain. In Britain, labor shortages led to the **conscription of women for work** in civil defense, military auxiliary services, factories, and in agriculture. In the US, women workers were employed in heavy industrial jobs traditionally reserved for men.

Black workers also took jobs that in peacetime were reserved for whites. This led to **racial tensions** that erupted into **rioting** in Detroit in June. White and black mobs clashed, and 34 people were killed before federal troops restored order.

One of the worst tragedies of 1943 was the **Bengal famine** that killed more than a million people in British India. Responsibility for this catastrophe is disputed, but Prime Minister Churchill refused to allow shipping space, which

almost 200,000 Asian laborers were **forced to build a railroad** from **Thailand** to supply Japanese troops in **Burma**. Around 16,000 POWs and 90,000 Asian workers died while they were building it.



Building the Burma Railroad
Alongside Asian forced laborers, chiefly British, Australian, and Dutch prisoners of war were used by the Japanese to build the railroad.

Marshal Pietro Badoglio

(1871–1956), signed an armistice with the Allies in early September. But the Germans had time to take over key positions in Italy and defend the peninsula against Allied invasion forces. German paratroopers rescued Mussolini

from captivity. They set him up as ruler of a puppet **Italian Social Republic**, which was founded in the town of Salo. As Allied forces fought their way northward from Naples toward Rome, the **Badoglio government joined the Allies**, declaring war on Germany.

